

Here he was, a boy, not quite 6 or 7. Somewhere in the middle. He boarded the plane with his mother, a lady he had only met twice before. The lady was somewhere the age of 26. In the lady's hands was the boy's sister, one of two. She had just turned 1.

The boy and his mother took their seats, and the sister remained in the lady's arms. The flight attendant walked over to the boy and said something. It was gibberish and the boy understood nothing. His mother nodded and smiled politely. The flight attendant reached down the side of the boy's left leg and pulled out a device. The boy immediately recognized what it was, and lost himself to it.

Time passed and the mother and her daughter fell asleep. The boy did not. The cabin of the airplane had its lights dimmed, and he could see his own reflection on the surface of the device. His reflection told him

he was sad. He was sad to leave his grandparents. They had taken care of him for the better of 6 or 7 years. No, there was no reason to be sad; he knew he would be back in their care. His mother had told him he was just going to some country to pick up an iPad and will come right back and return him to the grandparents.

He was wrong. The boy will not see his grandparents on home soil for at least another 10 years. Nor will he breathe the same air from the land that he was born in. The friends he had made in kindergarten will come by his grandparents' apartment, asking where he was, and leave with the same answer day after day.

Looking back at the boy's life, I do not know what was the right decision. However, I know for certain that if the same boy knew what awaited him for the next 6 years, he

would have fought tooth and nail to be left with his grandparents.

As he touched down in some strange new country, his father, a man he had never seen before, greeted him. The father put his arm around the boy, who burst into tears. He wanted his grandparents, but circumstances will prevent it for the foreseeable future. The father was happy, for he had finally held his son for the first time ever.

The family drove home, and the mother went straight to making dinner. Some sort of soup noodles was on the menu. The father gave the comfiest chair in the house for the boy to sit on. The boy himself had recovered from missing his grandparents, and wandered around the house, curious to this new environment he was in. The family had a housekeeper, and she was hanging up the laundry. She gave a kind smile to the boy and

said something to him. The boy never understood what she said, and never replied in any way.

After dinner, the housekeeper left, and it was time for bed. The boy slept in his own bed, whilst his sister, mother, and father slept in another. When he woke up, his father was gone. Off to work. The mother and the boy's sister were with him. The boy was quite proud of himself, for he did not cry through the night, as he was known to do so when spending the night somewhere that was not his grandparents' apartment.

The three ate breakfast, and the mother took the boy and his sister out to go sightseeing. The boy did not care. He did not understand what was so interesting that he saw. Rivers, beaches, parks, he had seen them all before. The only thing that piqued his interest was the food. He would soon later

learn that one of his favourite foods in this new country was called a “Potato Top Pie”.

Days passed, and the boy started getting used to the new country. He still could not understand a single thing people would say to him though. Additionally, the boy was starting primary school in a few weeks. He had to learn a new language, or else he would not be able to get anywhere in his new school.

And so, it began. In order to make sure his son knew some words in English and how to introduce himself, the father devised a demanding, if not cruel, regime. The boy was subjected to repeating the same word in a list verbally 10 times. The list contained 200 basic English words, such as “Hello”, “Hi”, “Good”, “Morning”, “Thanks”, and so on. He would do this before and after breakfast. Each word eventually became so ingrained in the boy’s

mind, tongue, and throat, that he would unconsciously tense up each time he spoke it, even 3 years later when he was a fluent speaker of the language.

After lunch, the boy was demanded by his father to write the list of words out, 5 times. Each word had to be written with precision, not scribbles. If the father did not like the boy's handwriting, he would demand the boy to re-write the word.

It was only after dinner that the boy had a break. This schedule was repeated for two weeks. If the boy complained or started crying out of frustration, the father hit him. The father physically abused his own son, and forced him to keep going with the demanding schedule.

The mother supported the father fully. Even when her own son had blood pouring out of his nose like a faucet, or the right side

of his face was swollen like a balloon, the mother did not step in to stop the father. She even contributed to the abuse, more with her tongue than her hands. With each slap, punch, kick, scold, the boy's heart greyed with coldness, and emotions died within. The boy rarely laughed or smiled in his household, and the abuse throughout his life almost entirely destroyed his ability to cry, to relieve sadness through tears. He became scared and mad of the figures that he was meant to love, meant to look up to. But no, this life was not going to be an easy one for him.

The housekeeper – I wish I could say stepped in and stopped the madness – turned a blind eye to such abuse. In the future, when the physical abuse lessened significantly to a point where it almost became 0, the boy would wonder what made the housekeeper comfortable around such

violence. The boy was wrong. The housekeeper was never comfortable around such violence, which was the reason why she always took her heart medications before coming to work.

All adults were once disobedient children, and that fact was proven when the boy started at his primary school. He was given a book to take home to read out loud with his parents, and he struggled greatly. Several words in the book were not in the list that his father gave him. The boy's father would say out loud one word and the boy successfully repeated it after him. However, the two would go over the entire book, and the boy could not memorize the pronunciation of upwards of 100 words in one sitting.

Of course the father became frustrated. Of course the only way he could resolve such frustration was to use physical abuse. Which

he did. Books became weapons to the boy. The covers of books would become deeply intimate with the face of the boy, as they were repeatedly smacked across them.

To make sure the boy never retreated into his own world when he took the beating, the father would scream and shout questions at the boy, and make him answer. The boy could not escape the violence even through his mind. The father had to make sure the boy knew pain, and the boy did. Each time the boy's nose got hit throughout his life, he would always be taken back to the times where his father struck him at the exact same space, which always produced a river of blood.

The housekeeper tried helping the boy out by teaching him the words – perhaps the only time she tried intervening – but the father was watching, and he even grew frustrated

just at the sight of his boy not being able to memorize all the words.

Blood from the boy's nose would stain the pages of the book, and the schoolteachers would become concerned for the boy's home life. The boy told them in broken English what happened at home (he thought there was nothing wrong with it) and the school's principal went to the boy's house to have a talk with the parents. I do not know what words were exchanged between them. This was the first time the boy told someone how his home life was.

It should come to no surprise that the boy's parents disobeyed the principal. Day after day, the same event would happen once the boy returned from school. Home, a place where every child takes solace in, became the complete opposite for the boy.

Due to the adults' at home having a disappointing ability in teaching, the school took note of the lack of progress of speaking in the boy, and assigned a specialized teacher to teach him English. That teacher was the school's librarian, Nina.

The boy and Nina will form a tight bond, something that will last all the way to the boy's adulthood, and beyond. In contrast to the style of teaching at home, Nina's was soft and patient, and the boy loved it. He learned more in one session with Nina than he had with the adults at home for two weeks. Nina also introduced one of the boy's favourite picture books: Mechanical Harry. This book would ignite a fire in the boy, a fire that burned deeply for problem solving and using it to ease burdens of everyday life. Nina showed to the boy that books were not to be used as weapons, but as sources that are rich

in knowledge, fuel for creativity, and the worlds that were created from a person's imagination.

In Nina's care, the boy's brain began to blossom in terms of creativity and imagination. The boy spent all his free time in the library, either being taught by Nina in English, or reading books that grabbed his attention.

At home, books were sources of pain and suffering, but in the school's library, books were keys to worlds where the boy could get himself lost in; to escape and forget what was waiting at home, even if it was just for a moment.

Fortunately, the father and the mother would eventually stop using books as their main source of pain to the boy. Unfortunately, that does not mean the abuse stopped. Even when the boy started to get the hang of the

English language, the parents would move onto something else to torment the boy with.

Next up was mathematics.

Through Nina's care and the parents' abuse, the boy's brain had been completely rewired, with its neuroplasticity being significantly increased. (I wonder if this would have been possible if these events took place later in the boy's life). The boy's brain was now a learning machine, and could grasp new stimuli much exceptionally faster than your average 7 year old.

Thus, the boy learned all the ways of addition and subtraction without much effort. Numbers started becoming more appealing to the boy. It was as if they danced exactly how the boy wanted, did exactly what he wanted, and the outcome was always the same. The boy loved it. However, a high capacity for learning did not mean the boy's

brain could go through processes faster. So the boy struggled with multiplication and division.

To help him, the father printed out a multiplication chart and had his son memorise it. When the boy thought he was ready, the father would say two numbers, and if the boy could not calculate the product of the two fast enough, the boy was sent back to memorising the chart.

Mathematics will eventually be a big part of the boy's life. He hated it, but definitely was quite good at it. Throughout the boy's early childhood – from 7 to 9 – the father would occasionally give out 150 tedious calculations for the boy to do by hand. This had negative and positive impacts, which will become apparent later in the boy's high school life.

While the boy's maths skills were above an average for his age, his English skills were still

much much below. The father and mother both did not like the boy's handwriting, and so they devised a regime to improve it. Whenever the boy had free time, the parents would make him handwrite text from magazines, books, newspapers, or whatever books that were available. If the parents did not like the appearance of words that the boy wrote, he was given a smack, and had to start all over again. He had to write through tears and blisters that formed on the inside of his finger.

Soon, the teachers at school noticed the boy's improved handwriting, and started complimenting the boy. Some would go as far as telling the parents that they had done a good job, not knowing what the boy had to go through. This gave the green light to the parents to continue their vile ways, as it was for the boy's "own good".

With Nina helping the boy with his English skills, and the parents at home exercising the boy's analytical mind, it soon became apparent that the usual school work of a Year 2 student was much too easy for the boy. Thus, the choice was made between the principal and the parents to have the boy skip Year 3. This was great news for both the parents and the boy. For the parents, their way of "teaching" and "discipline" had been proven, with the boy skipping a year being solid evidence. It is strange to me that even though the parents' thought their way of pedagogy was so successful, they would not repeat it onto their remaining children – at least not on the same scale as it was with their son. For the boy, skipping Year 3 to Year 4 was a pivotal decision that will shape the rest of his life.

2017 was the final year of primary teaching for Jason. It was also the year he met the boy. On the first day of teaching the boy, Jason knew he was in for a ride. The kid sitting before him would almost pick up anything Jason could throw at him, whether it was new maths concepts, the spelling of new words, the pronunciation of complex words, and even non-academic stimuli such as the steps to folding origami, the boy would consume it all. The boy surprised Jason with his voracity to learn and his capacity for retention.

Jason knew that he would only ever keep up with the boy for so long. So, he introduced the boy to something that will entertain him for a long time: programming. First, he taught the boy how to use a computer, and then taught him the concept of programming. It was the perfect stimulus for the boy, who got immediately hooked on it,

and would spend the rest of the school year rushing through the classwork to disappear off underneath a table to program and code something. Jason also worked closely with Nina, to ensure that whatever school work he gave to the boy matched the boy's current English skill.

Mostly, the boy created video games when he coded, due to the almost non-existent screen time he had at home. However, when it came to complex games, the boy did not have the knowledge nor mathematical ability to create such games. To help him, Jason advanced the boy even further than his peers. Algebra, graphs, and the basics of trigonometry were taught to the boy, who consumed all of it.

Jason and Nina became the type of mother and father that the boy desperately needed. School became a place of peace and

kindness, a place that contrasted deeply with the boy's home. The school and the home was a perfect ying and yang.

There was one big weakness with the boy's academic capability, and Jason knew that the boy would eventually come face to face with it. Every time Jason taught the boy something, it almost always seemed like the boy was just memorizing what he was saying, and not actually understanding it. Jason knew that this weakness of the boy would eventually consume him, and Jason was right. The boy thrived in analytical calculations, but immensely struggled with word problems and multi-step questions. It was as if the road to the solution was not straight, the boy would not be able to navigate himself to it. The boy also realised it himself as well. Each time he got a problem wrong, he always expected Jason to come

over and scream or slap his face. But no, Jason did not resort to violence. He attempted to help the boy with his weakness by teaching him problem solving skills, and not to always rely on rote learning. Just as how the softest ore remains a mere worthless pebble, a life that is full of ease will never take form. Growth and beauty comes from confronting the hammer and the heat.

Sadly, Jason did not know what the boy's home life was like at the time. Wanting the boy to improve his problem solving skills even further, he dropped off five booklets of problem solving activities at the boy's house for him to do over the school holidays. The boy would learn that any academic activity that falls into his parents hands has the potential to turn his life into suffering. The parents thanked Jason for having such care in their son, but this polite demeanor was

immediately removed when the teacher left. The boy was sent straight to work. He was made to do all the booklets by the time the school holidays were up. The father threatened the boy that if he made a single mistake, there would be hell to pay.

I know of the boy's current problem solving abilities. I am fairly certain that if the boy did not do those booklets with intense fear at the back of his head, he would have improved his problem solving abilities much further than he would have hoped. Of course, we know that is not the case. And so, in the future when the time called for exceptional problem solving abilities, the boy would always fall short. It was also always by the smallest of margins that he did so.